

PTI

ABHISHEK'S REPORT CARD

The Diamond Harbour MP is lauded by supporters and castigated by adversaries

PLUSES

- Was the architect of the 2021 assembly election victory: TMC won 215 out of 294 seats
- Battled anti-incumbency through the statewide Naba Jowar rally in 2023; helped win panchayat polls that year
- Based 2024 LS poll campaign on the stalling of central funds to Bengal; it helped TMC win 29 out of 42 seats

MINUSES

- Faces allegations of manipulating elections, including his own Diamond Harbour LS seat
- Charges of corruption in multiple scams—has been questioned by the CBI and ED in coal scam and teachers' recruitment scam
- Accused of running a shadow government in West Bengal

Former leader in the House Sudip Bandyopadhyay had been unwell and had let things slip. Chief whip Kalyan Banerjee was involved in a public spat with fellow MP Mahua Moitra in early August that rival parties and the media played up with a lot of glee. Curiously, Kalyan himself resigned from his post within a few hours of Abhishek's elevation. It was widely read as an angry response to the change, with some citing his earlier reservations about the young leader. But Kalyan dismissed this speculation, insisting that he shares a "very healthy relationship" with Abhishek. "He met me in Delhi and we had a very cordial meeting," he said. Yet, as a general fact, going beyond instances, a distinct inter-generational strain has accompanied Abhishek's rise to the top.

OLD ORDER CHANGETH

The battle with the veterans has been on since 2014, when Abhishek became the youngest Lok Sabha MP, winning from Diamond Harbour. Even preceding that was the rift between him and Suvendu Adhikari, who's since joined the BJP and is LoP in the assembly and is the TMC's most trenchant critic. That owed to the latter losing out in the battle to control the party's youth wing. In fact, the few quiet months after the frenetic activity of the 2024 election, when Abhishek was functioning mostly as party spokesperson, had led to speculation about a rift with Mamata. There was even talk that the machinations of the veterans had led to his sidelining. But Abhishek swung back into action later that year with a series of party rallies where a spirited avowal of allegiance to the party chief laid to rest the rumours.

Time is definitely on his side—so are a blend of other factors. Old-timers like state president Subrata Bakshi, Sudip and prominent leader Saugata Roy are all declining due to age and health issues. Kalyan, it appears, has lost the CM's confidence. Some other senior TMC leaders are in jail for alleged scams, like Partha Chattopadhyay (teacher's recruitment scam), or out on bail, like Jyotipriya Mallick (ration scam). Of Mamata's once formidable inner circle, only Aroop Biswas and Firhad Hakim remain. Both have had their differences with